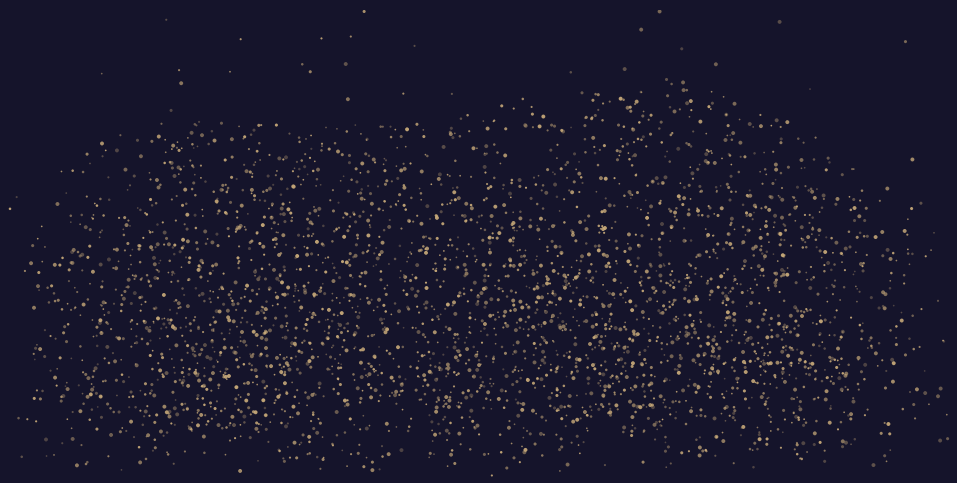
The King's Two Dreams

Oneiric Sovereignty, Narrative Mortality, and the Ethics of Succession in Neil Gaiman's The Sandman



A doctoral thesis
October 2026

τοῖς ἐγρηγορόσιν ἕνα καὶ κοινὸν κόσμον εἶναι, τῶν δὲ κοιμωμένων
ἕκαστον εἰς ἴδιον ἀποστρέφεσθαι.

The waking have one world in common; the sleepers turn aside,
each into a world of their own.

Heraclitus, fragment B89

Contents

	Abstract	4
	Note on Texts, Citation, and Orders of Relation	6
	Introduction: The Prince of Stories Has No Story	7
I	The Oneiric Commons	12
II	Dignities That Do Not Die	18
III	The Anarrative Sovereign	24
IV	The Political Theology of Abdication	30
V	The Ethics of Release and Its Limits	36
VI	Exiting the Oneiric Climate	42
VII	The Commonwealth of Fabulation	47
	Conclusion: The King's Two Dreams	52
	Works Cited	56
	Keywords	63

Abstract

This thesis offers a systematic philosophical reconstruction of Neil Gaiman's *The Sandman* (DC Comics/Vertigo, 1989–1996, with satellite texts through *Overture*, 2013–2015) and advances a new interpretive framework, here termed **kenotic oneirology**, according to which the series articulates a coherent metaphysics of fiction, a political theology of succession, and a theory of narrative mortality that its serial form simultaneously enacts. Against the dominant critical tendency, licensed by Gaiman's own précis that the King of Dreams "learns that one must change or die," to read the work as a story about stories, I argue that the formula conceals a deeper structural antinomy, the **paradox of the anarrative sovereign**: the Lord of Dreams, who administers every narrative, is the one being structurally barred from possessing a narrative of his own. As Walter Benjamin, Hannah Arendt, and Adriana Cavarero variously demonstrate, narrative derives its authority from death; the Endless, however, are constituted as dignities that do not die, in Ernst Kantorowicz's juridical sense. The series is therefore read as the protracted process by which a function becomes a self. Morpheus converts himself from office into narratable person through a graduated sequence of acts of release (Nada, Calliope, Orpheus) that culminate in a consensual abdication-by-death, whereupon the dignity of Dream passes intact to a successor of human birth.

The argument proceeds in four movements. **Part I** (Chapters One and Two) reconstructs the ontology of the Dreaming as an *oneiric commons*, a shared domain constituted by the bounded privacy of individual dreams (Heraclitus DK B89) and sustained by the cosmological labour of sleepers (DK B75). It proposes a *graded fabulative ontology* in which beings persist according to the mode of their support (belief, function, narration, finitude), reads the Endless as offices of consciousness rather than gods, Forms, or archetypes, and models the heptad as a structured system mediated by Dream in the role of a transcendental schematism. **Part II** (Chapter Three) develops the narratological core: Todorov's law that narration equals life, Benjamin's law that death sanctions narration, the Aristotelian opposition of *energeia* and *kinesis*, the Makropulos problem as tested by Hob Gadling, and Ricoeur's dialectic of *idem* and *ipse*. **Part III** (Chapters Four and Five) elaborates a political theology of abdication (Destruction, Lucifer, Augustus, Harun al-Rashid, Prospero, Morpheus) through Kantorowicz, Schmitt, Agamben, Frazer, Girard, Jung's *Answer to Job*, and the theology of kenosis, then submits the series' *grammar of release* to sustained critique, identifying an *Oresteian remainder* in which mater-

nal grievance is absorbed into paternal succession and examining the limits of benevolent sovereignty in *A Game of You* and "Ramadan." **Part IV** (Chapters Six and Seven) argues that the decision to end constitutes an exit from what Umberto Eco called the *oneiric climate* of the serial superhero, reads *The Wake* as a Benjaminian awakening (*Erwachen*), diagnoses the franchise afterlife and the work's post-2024 reception as a re-enactment of the doctrine of the two bodies at the level of the literary institution, and situates the series comparatively among Borges, Calvino, Calderón, Chesterton, Kafka, Goethe, Mann, Le Guin, Pullman, Pratchett, Dunsany, Lovecraft, Zelazny, Moore, and Morrison.

The thesis concludes that *The Sandman*'s central philosophical achievement is not a defence of fiction but a theory of how fictions outlive their sovereigns. Mutability is the only form of mortality available to the immortal; succession is the only form of immortality available to the narratable.

Note on Texts, Citation, and Orders of Relation

References to *The Sandman* cite issue number (#1–75) and, where useful, the collected volume: *Preludes & Nocturnes* (#1–8), *The Doll's House* (#9–16), *Dream Country* (#17–20), *Season of Mists* (#21–28), *A Game of You* (#32–37), *Fables & Reflections* (#29–31, #38–40, #50, and *The Sandman Special* #1), *Brief Lives* (#41–49), *Worlds' End* (#51–56), *The Kindly Ones* (#57–69), and *The Wake* (#70–75). Satellite texts are *Death: The High Cost of Living* (1993), *Death: The Time of Your Life* (1996), *The Dream Hunters* (1999), *Endless Nights* (2003), and *The Sandman: Overture* (2013–15). Gaiman's text is paraphrased rather than reproduced, save for phrases of a few words where the argument turns on exact wording.

Classical and early modern sources are cited by conventional divisions: Diels–Kranz numbering for the Presocratics, Stephanus pagination for Plato, Bekker numbers for Aristotle, book and line for epic, book, canto, and stanza for Spenser, and A/B pagination for Kant's first *Critique*. Translations are the author's unless otherwise indicated.

The study distinguishes three **orders of relation** between *The Sandman* and its antecedents, and marks them where the distinction bears weight:

1. **Citation**: explicit allusion legible on the page (Ovid's Morpheus, Aeschylus' Kindly Ones, Shakespeare's *Dream* and *Tempest*, Milton's Lucifer, Hoffmann's eye-stealing Sandman, Chesterton's likeness lent to Fiddler's Green).
2. **Filiation**: influence documented by the author, by the editorial apparatus, or by the work's inheritance of prior DC properties (Alan Moore's *Swamp Thing*, the Simon–Kirby and Fox–Christman Sandmen, Dunsany, Cabell, Lovecraft's Dreamlands).
3. **Affinity**: structural homology for which no influence is claimed (Heraclitus, Kantorowicz, Benjamin, Ricoeur, Spenser's *Mutabilitie*). Unless otherwise marked, philosophical comparanda belong to this third order, and the argument is that they illuminate what the work does, not what its author read.



Introduction

The Prince of Stories Has No Story

*I.*1 The Problem

In the final issue of *The Sandman* (#75, "The Tempest"), the Lord of Dreams visits William Shakespeare at Stratford in 1610 to collect the second of two commissioned plays and confesses that, although he is Prince of Stories, he has no story of his own. He has asked for a play about a magician who drowns his book, breaks his staff, and leaves his island, because that is the one thing he himself cannot do. Placed after the death and funeral of its speaker, the confession functions as the work's retrospective key. It also exposes the insufficiency of the consensus that has governed the work's reception since Hy Bender's *The Sandman Companion* (1999): that *The Sandman* is a story about stories, whose protagonist learns, in Gaiman's often-repeated formula, that one must change or die.

The consensus is accurate but philosophically underdetermined. It names a theme without accounting for a structure. It cannot explain why a being defined as the sovereign of all narrative should be the one being without narrative. It cannot explain why the alternative presented to him is disjunctive (change *or* die) when the outcome is conjunctive: he changes *by* dying. It cannot explain why the series is populated, with almost liturgical regularity, by sovereigns who renounce sovereignty (Destruction, Lucifer, Augustus, Harun al-Rashid, Prospero), or why its ontology distinguishes so carefully between gods, who perish when forgotten, and the Endless, who do not. Nor can it explain why a mainstream serial comic, whose commercial logic depends on perpetual middles, should insist upon an ending.

*I.*2 The Argument

This thesis contends that these questions share a single answer, located at the intersection of two theorems that the series dramatizes without stating. The first is narratological, and receives its canonical formulation in Walter Benjamin's essay "The Storyteller" (1936): death is the sanction of everything the storyteller can tell, because a life first assumes transmissible form at its end. The second is juridical-theological, and receives its canonical formulation in Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957): the dignity never dies (*dignitas non moritur*), because the office persists through the mortality of its incumbents. A being who is all dignity and no mortality is, by the first theorem, unnarratable. The Prince of Stories is such a being. I call this structure the **paradox of the anarrative sovereign**, and argue that *The Sandman* is the 75-issue resolution of it. The argument is organized as four propositions.

1. **The ontological proposition.** The Dreaming is an *oneiric commons*: a shared order constituted by the partition of private worlds and sustained by the labour of

sleepers. Being within the series is graded by its mode of support (belief, function, narration, finitude), yielding a *ladder of persistence* that explains the differential mortality of gods, Endless, dream-creatures, and humans.

2. **The officiary proposition.** The Endless are neither gods, Platonic Forms, nor Jungian archetypes but *dignities*: corporations sole of conscious life, whose incumbents are persons only derivatively. Within the heptad, Dream occupies the role of a *schematism*, the function by which the other six become figurable to finite minds.
3. **The narratological-ethical proposition.** Narrative selfhood requires mutability, of which death is the limit case. The immortal office-holder can acquire a narratable self only through **kenotic succession**: a self-emptying transfer of the dignity to a successor, purchased by the death of the person. Morpheus' arc converts Ricoeurian *idem* (sedimented character) into *ipse* (selfhood as fidelity) through acts of release and promise, culminating in an abdication-by-death.
4. **The formal-historical proposition.** The series enacts its doctrine at the level of its medium, exiting what Umberto Eco termed the *oneiric climate* of serial comics through the death of its protagonist; and its institutional afterlife (spin-offs, prequels, adaptations, and a transformed authorial reception) re-enacts the doctrine of the two bodies at the level of the literary institution.

The synthesis of these propositions is named **kenotic oneirology**, and the thesis's title condenses it. *The King's Two Dreams* designates, first, the dream the king administers, the Dreaming as body politic, the commons of all sleepers; and second, the dream the king *is*, Morpheus as body natural, a person who appears differently to every perceiver and who is, in the most literal sense, dreamt by those who behold him. The tragedy of the series is the incommensurability of these two dreams; its resolution is their separation.

I.3 Method, Corpus, and the Question of the Author

Methodologically, the study practises comparative philosophical criticism in the tradition that treats literary form as itself a mode of philosophical claim, as articulated by Martha Nussbaum in *Love's Knowledge* (1990): certain truths about finite life are statable only in narrative form, and a reading that extracts propositions from a narrative loses precisely what the narrative knows. The thesis therefore moves between three registers: the philosophical (what the work claims), the genealogical (from whom it inherits those claims, distinguished by the orders of citation, filiation, and affinity), and the formal (how the medium of sequential art, with its gutters, braided

motifs, rotating artists, and serial publication, makes the claims). Comics-theoretical vocabulary is drawn from Scott McCloud, Thierry Groensteen, and Charles Hatfield.

The question of the author cannot be bracketed by a study published in 2026. In July 2024 the Tortoise Media podcast *Master* broadcast the first allegations that Gaiman had sexually assaulted or coerced women; in January 2025 a *New York* magazine investigation by Lila Shapiro set out allegations of assault, abuse, and coercion from eight women, most concerning encounters when Gaiman was in his forties or older. One of the eight, Scarlett Pavlovich, became nanny to the son of Gaiman and Amanda Palmer in New Zealand. In suits filed against Gaiman and Palmer in February 2025, she alleged that Gaiman sexually assaulted her on the night they met in February 2022; that the assaults, which she has described to *New York* as including rape, continued; and that she remained in the household because she was homeless and without money and because Gaiman had promised to help her writing career. Her suits were withdrawn or dismissed, the principal one, in Wisconsin, on the ground that New Zealand, where the conduct was alleged to have occurred, was the appropriate forum; the Seventh Circuit upheld that dismissal in 2026, and no court in the United States has ruled on the merits. Gaiman denies every allegation. He has stated that he has never engaged in non-consensual sexual activity with anyone; his lawyers have described the relationship as brief and consensual, have told the court that New Zealand police investigated her complaint and found it meritless, and have characterized her suits as part of a plan to smear him. The allegations bear with particular force on texts in which the series anatomizes extractive authorship, above all "Calliope" (#17), in which a celebrated novelist holds a Muse captive and rapes her to secure his inspiration. The force is structural rather than merely biographical. What is alleged in the gravest account, that a famous author sexually assaulted a young woman who was homeless and employed in his household, while holding out help with her writing, is the relation the story indicts in its novelist: sexual access taken from a woman whose dependence makes refusal costly, with literary capital on the other side of the exchange. This thesis adjudicates no biographical claim. Its position is twofold. First, the critical resources the text supplies for analysing the ethics of authorship are the text's, and they may be turned against any author, including its own. Second, the separability of a work from its author is not a methodological axiom to be assumed (Barthes) nor a scandal to be denied, but one of the problems the work itself theorizes, through the separability of the office of Dream from the person of Morpheus. Chapter Six returns to this as the problem of *the two bodies of the author*.

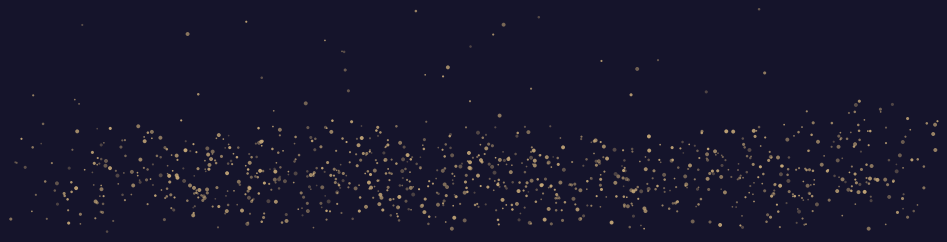
*I.*4 Plan of the Study

Chapter One reconstructs the ontology of the Dreaming through Heraclitus, an inverted Plato, Kant, Schopenhauer, and the series' arch-enemy of fiction, John Dee. Chapter Two reads the Endless genealogically (Hesiod to Dunsany) and structurally (the heptad as system). Chapter Three develops the theory of the anarrative sovereign through Benjamin, Arendt, Cavarero, Todorov, Aristotle, Williams, Ricoeur, and Heraclitus' dictum that character is destiny. Chapter Four sets out the political theology of abdication. Chapter Five submits the series' ethics of release to critique. Chapter Six turns to medium, seriality, and institution. Chapter Seven maps comparative coordinates across speculative and philosophical fiction. The Conclusion states the doctrine of kenotic oneirology in a sequence of numbered theses.

I

The Oneiric Commons

The Dreaming is neither a psyche nor a heaven but a commons: a shared order whose condition of existence is the preservation of private worlds within it, and whose reality is continuously produced by the labour of those who sleep.



1.1 Idios Kosmos, Koinos Kosmos: Heraclitus and the Vortex

Heraclitus, as transmitted by Plutarch, distinguishes the waking, who share a single common world (*koinos kosmos*), from the sleeping, each of whom turns aside into a world of their own (*idios kosmos*) (DK B89). A second fragment, preserved by Marcus Aurelius (*Meditations* VI.42), complicates the first: the sleepers, too, are workers and co-workers in what comes to pass in the cosmos (DK B75). A third binds sleep to death, describing the sleeper as one who touches the dead while living (DK B26). These three fragments, read together, furnish the most exact available description of the Dreaming. Each dreamer inhabits an *idios kosmos*; yet all such worlds are islands within a single administered realm, and their collective activity is not epiphenomenal but cosmologically productive.

The series stages the threat to this arrangement in *The Doll's House* (#9–16). Rose Walker is a *vortex*, a being whose presence dissolves the partitions between individual dreams. Dream explains that, should the walls fall, all dreams would merge into one, destroying first the Dreaming and then the waking world. The vortex is the Heraclitean distinction collapsing from the side of sleep: a total *koinos* without any *idios*, a single dream dreamt by all. Its political analogue is the abolition of plurality, which Hannah Arendt identified in *The Human Condition* (1958) as the condition of all action. The resolution is allegorically exact. Rose's grandmother, **Unity** Kinkaid, who slept through most of her life in the encephalitis lethargica epidemic that Dream's captivity caused, takes the vortex into herself and dies in her granddaughter's place. Unity dies so that plurality may live. The allegory rests on an injury the arc discloses only at its close. While Unity lay in the sleeping sickness, unable to wake or to consent, Desire took human form and raped her, fathering the child through whom the vortex descended to Rose. Desire's aim was that Dream would kill Rose, his own kin, and so bring the Furies upon himself. The commons is saved by a woman whose body had first been made the instrument of a quarrel among the Endless, a pattern Chapter Five traces through Nada, Calliope, and Lyta Hall. Dream's sovereignty is accordingly revealed as constitutional rather than absolute: he governs not the contents of dreams but the partitions between them, and his gravest duty is the maintenance of difference. It is a duty he could not discharge for Unity, violated inside the very sickness his captivity had caused.

1.2 Plato Inverted: Between Form, Category, and Archetype

Plato's divided line assigns images and dreams the lowest rung of cognition (*eikasia*), and in *Republic* 476c–d he defines the dreamer as one who takes the likeness for the thing itself. *The Sandman* inverts this hierarchy without abandoning its terms. In "A

Midsummer Night's Dream" (#19), Dream holds that things need not have happened to be true, and that tales and dreams are truths of shadow that outlast mere fact. The Dreaming is the domain in which likenesses are acknowledged as likenesses and thereby acquire a durability that the facts they shadow lack. The inversion is not anti-Platonic but trans-Platonic: the image becomes a Form precisely by confessing that it is an image.

Three post-Platonic frameworks locate the Dreaming more precisely.

- **Kant.** The first *Critique* calls the imagination a blind but indispensable function of the soul, without which there would be no cognition at all (A78/B103), and describes the schematism as an art hidden in the depths of the soul (A141/B180–181). The Dreaming is not the content of experience but the condition of its figurability: a transcendental imagination given a geography and a sovereign.
- **Schopenhauer.** In *The World as Will and Representation* (I, §5), life and dreams are leaves of one and the same book: reading it in order is waking life, and idly turning its pages at random is dreaming. The image is uncannily precise for *The Sandman*, in which **Destiny** walks bound to a book that records every event in sequence, while **Dream** presides over the same totality read out of order. The two eldest brothers are two modes of reading one book.
- **Jung.** The Dreaming resembles the collective unconscious, but differs from it decisively. Jung's archetypes are forms without content; the Endless are content-rich persons with grievances, siblings, and debts. The Dreaming is not unconscious but administered. Gaiman socializes the archetype, converting a psychology into a polity.

The nearest psychoanalytic concept is D. W. Winnicott's *potential space* ("Transitional Objects and Transitional Phenomena," 1953; *Playing and Reality*, 1971): an intermediate area of experience about which the question "did you create this, or did you find it?" must never be asked. The Dreaming institutionalizes that prohibition. It is neither discovered nor invented; it is the place where the difference is suspended. A further comparison demands care. The term "the Dreaming" entered English partly through Baldwin Spencer and F. J. Gillen's gloss of the Arrernte *altyerre* (*alcheringa*) as "dream times" (1899), a rendering W. E. H. Stanner later sought to correct with his coinage "everywhen" ("The Dreaming," 1953). The gloss's senior author did not confine himself to description. Appointed Special Commissioner and Chief Protector of Aboriginals in the Northern Territory in 1912, Spencer proposed in his *Preliminary Report* of 1913 that Aboriginal children be taken from their parents and raised on reserves where they would be denied contact with their families, prevented from speaking their languages, and made incapable of living in the bush;

he insisted above all that children of mixed descent be removed from the camps. The Kahlin Compound opened outside Darwin the same year, and *Bringing Them Home* (1997), the report of the national inquiry into the forced separation of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander children from their families, cites his report in its account of the Northern Territory. Gaiman's Dreaming is a European mythopoeic construct that inherits, perhaps unknowingly, an anthropological mistranslation; the affinity it shares with Stanner's everywhen (a realm outside sequence that grounds the present) is real, but the borrowing is not symmetrical. The word reached English through the work of a man who also proposed taking Aboriginal children from their families, and a European fantasy that names its realm with it inherits the vocabulary of a dispossession along with the mistranslation. The thesis's own term, the oneiric commons, should be read with that history in view: it names a commons built partly from a word taken from people whose land was being enclosed and whose children were being taken.

1.3 The Enemy of Fiction: John Dee and the Life-Lie

The first antagonist of the series is a fanatic of truth. In "24 Hours" (#6), John Dee, possessed of Dream's ruby, sits in a diner and, over a single day, strips its six occupants of the capacity to dissimulate. Among them is the waitress Bette Munroe, who composes stories about her customers in which each receives a happy ending. Hour by hour, Dee forces them to confess their secrets, stages an orgy among them, sets them to fight, makes them worship him, and drives them to mutilate themselves and one another; by the twenty-second hour each has killed another or themselves, and all six are dead. In #7 he turns the stone upon the world's sleepers, and the waking world goes mad. The structure is a precise inversion of the series' ontology. Dee would abolish the *idios kosmos* of private fiction in the name of a single unbearable *koinos* of truth. The violence is the argument, not its ornament: stripped of their protective fictions, Dee's captives are not freed into truth but delivered into his power, and the demolition of their life-lies is the instrument of their deaths.

Dee belongs to a philosophical lineage.

- **Plato** expels the poets (*Republic* II–III, X) while licensing the noble lie (414b–c); Dee is the Platonic censor without the noble lie, purity without polity.
- **Nietzsche**, in "On Truth and Lies in a Nonmoral Sense" (1873), describes truths as illusions whose illusory character has been forgotten; Dee wishes to strip the metaphors from the world and finds nothing beneath them but violence.

- **Wilde**, in "The Decay of Lying" (1889), defends the telling of beautiful untrue things as the proper aim of art and argues that life imitates art far more than art imitates life.
- **Ibsen** supplies the closest dramatic analogue, and the series signals the debt in the title of its second volume. In *The Wild Duck* (1884), Gregers Werle insists on the "claim of the ideal," exposes the founding deception of the Ekdal household, and sets in motion the events that end with the fourteen-year-old Hedvig taking her own life; the physician Relling replies that to take away an ordinary man's life-lie (*livsløgnen*) is to take away his happiness. Dee is Gregers Werle with a sorcerer's stone; the diner is the Ekdal attic.

The series' positive counterpart is Joshua Norton ("Three Septembers and a January," #31), the bankrupt whom Dream rescues from Despair with a dream of empire, and whom nineteenth-century San Francisco sustains as Emperor of the United States by honouring his fiction. Hans Vaihinger's *Philosophy of 'As If'* (1911) theorized such fictions as indispensable instruments; Calderón's Segismundo had already concluded that even in dreams the doing of good is not lost (*La vida es sueño*, 1635). Against Dee's demolition stands a civic practice of collaborative make-believe.

1.4 Retroactive Ontogenesis: The Thousand Cats

In "A Dream of a Thousand Cats" (#18), a cat-prophet teaches that the world was once otherwise, cats vast and humans small, until enough humans dreamt it into its present form; and that when the world changes in this way, it becomes as though it had always been so. The doctrine is stronger than idealism. It asserts **retroactive ontogenesis**: a sufficiently collective fabulation rewrites not only the present but the past. Borges' "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940) imagines an invented world whose objects begin to infiltrate and overwrite the real; Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Lathe of Heaven* (1971) gives George Orr "effective dreams" that remake the world and its history overnight. Philip K. Dick's dictum that reality is whatever does not go away when one stops believing in it (1978) supplies the negative criterion against which the cats' doctrine is defined: in the Dreaming's jurisdiction, what does not go away is precisely what enough beings refuse to stop dreaming.

The cats' ontology is irreducibly political. A thousand dreamers constitute a *demos*; the world is a majority settlement, revisable by plebiscite. Heraclitus' sleepers as co-workers (B75) here become sleepers as electors. The contrast with Dee is complete: Dee imposes one dream on all; the cats propose that all dream one dream by consent.

1.5 The Ladder of Persistence: A Graded Fabulative Ontology

The series distinguishes beings by what keeps them in existence. The resulting hierarchy, here called the **ladder of persistence**, is the ontological ground of the entire argument.

Mode	Support	Exemplars	Mortality
Doxic	Belief and worship	The gods of *Season of Mists* and *Brief Lives* (Bast, Odin, Ishtar, Pharamond)	Fade when forgotten; survive by adaptation
Officiary	A function exercised by living beings	The Endless	Persist while the function persists; incumbents replaceable
Diegetic	Narration and dreaming	The Corinthian, Fiddler's Green, Cain and Abel, the unwritten books of Lucien's library	Unmade and remade by their author; repeat their story
Mortal	Embodied finitude	Humans and other living beings	Die, but become transmissible as story

The distinctions are argued, not assumed. Pharamond, a former god now running a travel agency, survives by changing his trade; Ishtar, reduced to dancing in a strip club, dies in a final dance (*Brief Lives*). Bergson's *Two Sources of Morality and Religion* (1932) derived the gods from a *fabulatory function*, a defensive reaction of life against intelligence's discovery of death; *The Sandman* adopts the derivation and adds its corollary, that the fabulated die when fabulation ceases. Amie Thomasson's artifactualism (*Fiction and Metaphysics*, 1999) holds that fictional characters are abstract artifacts, dependent on their creators' acts and on the continued existence of texts and competent readers; Thomasson describes the diegetic mode almost exactly. The Endless are the anomaly no such theory anticipates: neither concrete, nor artifactual, nor Meinongian, they exist as long as the activity they name is performed.

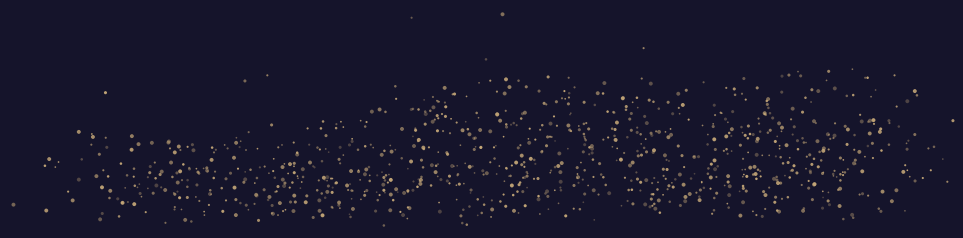
Lucien's library adds a modal refinement. Borges' Library of Babel (1941) contains every possible book; Lucien's contains only books that were dreamt and never written. It is not a library of the possible but of the *dreamt-actual*, a third modality between act and possibility, and an archive of what Giorgio Agamben calls potentiality-not-to: works that could have passed into act and did not.

The ladder clarifies the series' central movement. Morpheus begins in the officiary mode and ends in the diegetic: his death converts him from a function into a story, told by the mourners of *The Wake*, while the office passes intact to Daniel. Kenosis, in the ontology of *The Sandman*, is a descent of exactly one rung.

II

Dignities That Do Not Die

The Endless are offices of conscious life: impersonal dignities that outlast their incumbents, inherited from the oldest Western grammar of personification and reconfigured as a system in which Dream mediates the rest.



2.1 Genealogies of Personification

The Endless have a pedigree older than any of the gods who quarrel over Hell in *Season of Mists*. Hesiod's *Theogony* (211–225) gives Night (Nyx), without a partner, a brood that reads as a proto-heptad: Moros (Doom) and the Moirai (Fates), Thanatos (Death), Hypnos (Sleep) with the tribe of Oneiroi (Dreams), Oizys (Woe), Philotes (Affection), Apate (Deceit), and Eris (Strife). The correspondences with Destiny, Death, Dream, Despair, Desire, Delirium, and Destruction are not one-to-one, but the principle is identical: the conditions of mortal experience are the children of a single primordial darkness. The late prequel *Overture* (2013–15) makes the filiation explicit by giving the Endless parents, Night and Time. Homer had already made Sleep and Death twin brothers, who bear the body of Sarpedon home to Lycia (*Iliad* 16.672–683); the sibling bond between Dream and Death is thus a citation of the epic's oldest stratum.

The name Morpheus is Ovidian. In the House of Sleep (*Metamorphoses* XI), Somnus has a thousand sons, of whom Morpheus alone imitates human forms; he appears to Alcyone in the likeness of her drowned husband Ceyx. Gaiman's Morpheus inherits this mimetic plasticity, generalized into a principle: he takes the form his beholder can perceive. Virgil supplies the topography of false dreams, which cling beneath the leaves of a vast elm at the threshold of the underworld (*Aeneid* VI.282–284), and, with Homer, the two gates of sleep, of horn for true dreams and ivory for false (*Odyssey* 19.560–567; *Aeneid* VI.893–898).

The medieval tradition converted personification into a method of thought. Prudentius' *Psychomachia* (c. 405) stages virtues and vices in combat; Boethius' Lady Philosophy consoles a prisoner (c. 524); the *Roman de la Rose* (c. 1230–1275) fuses personification with the dream vision; Chaucer's *Book of the Duchess* opens with Morpheus, and his *Parlement of Foules*, a dream vision convened among birds, stands behind the title "The Parliament of Rooks" (#40). Spenser's *Two Cantos of Mutabilitie* (1609) are the decisive early modern precedent and are treated in Chapter Three: the titaness Mutability claims sovereignty over the gods, and Nature rules that things are not changed from their first estate but by their change their being do dilate (VII.vii.58). Blake's *Four Zoas* (c. 1797–1807) then gives the Romantic form: a fractured family of cosmic-psychic powers (Urizen, Los, Luvah, Tharmas), fragments of a single fallen Man, whose quarrels are at once theological and psychological. The Endless are a family of the same kind.

The modern folkloric lineage is equally direct.

- **Andersen.** In "Ole Lukøje" (1841), the Sandman carries two umbrellas, one painted with dreams for good children and one blank for the rest; and he has a

brother, also called Ole Lukøje, who is Death and rides a horse. The Dream–Death siblinghood is a citation.

- **Hoffmann.** In "Der Sandmann" (1816), the Sandman throws sand in children's eyes until they leap bleeding from their heads. Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919) read the tale through the fear of losing one's eyes. Gaiman's Corinthian, a nightmare with mouths in place of eyes who eats the eyes of his victims, is Hoffmann's Sandman detached from the office and loosed as a rogue creation.
- **Chesterton.** *The Man Who Was Thursday: A Nightmare* (1908) personifies the days of the week as members of an anarchist council who prove to be its policemen; the dream-place Fiddler's Green, when it takes human form, takes Chesterton's.
- **Dunsany.** *The Gods of Pegāna* (1905) presents a cosmos dreamt by a sleeping god, MĀNA-YOOD-SUSHĀĪ, kept asleep by the drummer Skarl, whose waking would end all things.

Finally, Gaiman absorbs the archive of his publisher. The 1939 Sandman of Gardner Fox and Bert Christman (Wesley Dodds), the 1974 Sandman of Joe Simon and Jack Kirby (with Brute and Glob), and the hosts of DC's horror anthologies (Cain, Abel, Lucien, Eve, Destiny, the three witches) are all recuperated as residents of the Dreaming. The recuperation is a theory of persistence in miniature: discarded properties survive by being re-dreamt.

2.2 Neither Gods nor Forms: The Endless as Corporations Sole

The series insists that the Endless are not gods. Gods depend on worship and die when forgotten; the Endless depend on the activities they name. Three precedents establish that the Endless are offices rather than persons: the present Despair is not the first, her predecessor having died and been replaced; Delirium was once Delight, so that an incumbent can mutate while the office continues; and Destruction abandoned his realm at the close of the seventeenth century, after which things went on being destroyed without him (*Brief Lives*). An office whose function continues without its holder is, in the language of English law, a **corporation sole**.

Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* reconstructs the Tudor juristic doctrine, recorded in Plowden's *Reports*, that the king possesses a body natural, mortal and fallible, and a body politic, which cannot die, err, or be a minor. The doctrine yields the formula *dignitas non moritur* and the acclamation "the King is dead; long live the King." Every Endless is a twin-born being in this sense. Morpheus is a body nat-

ural (moody, proud, guilt-ridden, given to grand gestures and sullen rains); Dream is a body politic (the realm, the function, the regalia).

The series' first arc reads, under this description, as a restoration narrative. Burgess' seventy-two-year imprisonment of Dream is an **interregnum**, during which the realm decays and pretenders arise (Brute and Glob's false Sandman). The quest of *Preludes & Nocturnes* for the pouch, the helm, and the ruby is the recovery of the **regalia**. The series' last arc is a demise of the Crown: the body natural is destroyed by the Kindly Ones, the body politic passes to Daniel, and *The Wake* conducts the obsequies of the one and the investiture of the other. Destruction's resignation and Dream's death are therefore not equivalent. Destruction's function is self-executing and governs itself without him; the Dreaming, as *Preludes* shows, decays without a sovereign, because story requires a teller. **Destruction can resign; Dream can only die.**

2.3 The Heptad as a System

The seven Endless form a structure rather than a list. Three polar axes can be distinguished, mediated by a fourth term.

Axis	Pole	Counter-pole	Philosophical key
Modal	Destiny: necessity, the book read in order	Delirium: contingency beyond possibility	Boethius, Leibniz; Plato's *Phaedrus* on divine madness
Ontic	Death: cessation of a being	Destruction: transformation of form	Epicurus, Heidegger; Heraclitean flux
Affective	Desire: appetite, lack in motion	Despair: lack arrested	Schopenhauer's pendulum; Kierkegaard's *Sickness unto Death*
Mediating	Dream: the figuration of all the above	(none)	Kant's schematism; Freud's dream-work

The twins Desire and Despair are the most transparent case. Schopenhauer describes life as a pendulum swinging between the pain of unsatisfied willing and the vacancy that follows satisfaction (*World as Will*, I, §57); Lacan describes desire as the metonymy of lack, perpetually displaced onto new objects. Desire is lack that keeps moving; Despair is lack that has stopped. They are twins because they are one privation in two tempos. One of Despair's attributes confirms the Kierkegaardian key in the table above: she wears a hooked ring with which she wounds her own skin. Kierkegaard defines despair as a misrelation in the self's relation to itself, a sickness unto death whose torment is that it consumes the self without being able to destroy it (*Sickness unto Death*, Part One); Despair's self-wounding renders that

definition as an image, and makes her the one Endless whose function is turned back upon her own body. Delirium, formerly Delight, distributes the four divine madnesses of the *Phaedrus* (244a–245a, 265b): prophetic, ritual, poetic, and erotic.

Dream stands at the centre because each of the others becomes available to finite minds only through figuration. Necessity appears as the prophetic dream, contingency as the absurd dream, cessation as the dream of the dead, transformation as metamorphosis, appetite as wish-fulfilment, privation as nightmare. In Kant, the schema mediates between pure concept and sensible intuition; in Freud, the dream-work (condensation, displacement, considerations of representability, secondary revision) converts latent thoughts into images. Dream is the **schematism of the Endless**. The structural position explains his protagonism: he is the Endless through whom the others become narratable. It also explains his predicament. A schema is a procedure, not an object; it has no content of its own. The Prince of Stories lacks a story as the schematism lacks a referent.

2.4 Perspectival Ontology and the Multiplicity of Hands

The Endless appear differently to every beholder. Dream is Kai'ckul to Nada, Oneiros to the Greeks, a black cat to cats, and a figure of flame to the Martian J'onn J'onzz, who names him L'Zoril. This is not disguise but **perspectival ontology**. Leibniz writes that one and the same city viewed from different sides appears entirely different and is as if multiplied in perspective (*Monadology* §57); Nietzsche, that there is only a perspectival seeing and a perspectival knowing (*Genealogy of Morals* III, §12).

The series' rotating roster of artists (Sam Kieth, Mike Dringenberg, Kelley Jones, Charles Vess, Jill Thompson, P. Craig Russell, Marc Hempel, Michael Zulli, Jon J Muth, among others) converts a contingency of production into a formal enactment of this ontology. No canonical Dream exists; each artist renders a different Morpheus, and Gaiman's scripts were written to each artist's capacities. Identity across the run is secured not by any single feature but by overlapping iconographic constants (pallor, black cloak, eyes like stars, the helm). Dream's identity is a Wittgensteinian family resemblance (*Philosophical Investigations* §§66–67), and the reader experiences him exactly as the series says mortals experience the Endless: as a pattern recognizable only across its variations.

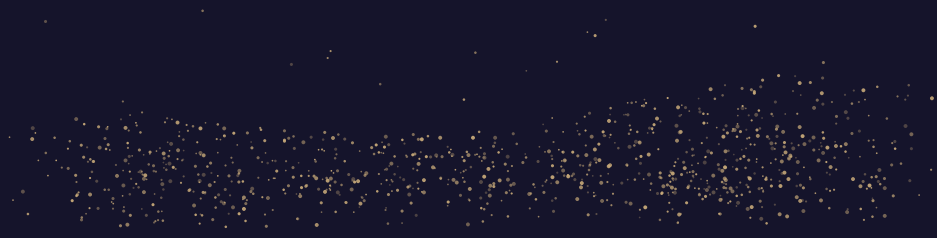
Two further formal elements confirm the homology. Todd Klein's lettering gives each Endless a graphic voice: Dream speaks in inverted balloons, white letters on black; Delirium in polychrome, irregular script. In a medium where voice is always already writing, personhood is a matter of inscription. Dave McKean's mixed-media covers, which repeatedly embed a framed image of Dream, function as what Gérard

Genette called *seuils*, thresholds of the text. It is apt that Desire's realm is named the Threshold: the series' paratext, like its most seductive Endless, is a body one enters through a door.

III

The Anarrative Sovereign

Narrative selfhood is the privilege of beings who can change, and death is change's limit case; the sovereign of stories, being changeless, is the one being without a story, and can acquire one only by dying.



3.1 The Authority of Death: Benjamin, Arendt, Cavarero

Benjamin's "The Storyteller" (1936) locates the source of narrative authority in mortality. Not only knowledge and wisdom but above all a person's lived life first assumes transmissible form at the moment of death; the storyteller borrows authority from death. Arendt, in *The Human Condition* (§§24–25), extends the claim to the disclosure of persons. Who someone is (as opposed to *what* they are) appears in action and speech, but becomes a tangible and meaningful whole only in the story told by others after the actor's life has ended; the actor never sees the meaning of their own deeds, which belongs to the storyteller. Adriana Cavarero, in *Relating Narratives* (1997), names the consequence: the self is *narratable*, and desires its story from another. Her emblem is Odysseus at the Phaeacian court, weeping as the bard Demodocus sings of Troy (*Odyssey* 8), receiving for the first time the meaning of his own life from another's mouth.

These three theses converge on Dream's confession in #75. The being who governs every narrative possesses none, and the reason is structural rather than psychological. Narrative is the form in which a finite life is gathered into meaning; a being without finitude cannot be so gathered. The Prince of Stories is therefore the **anarrative sovereign**: the condition of all narratability, himself unnarratable. *The Wake* (#70–75) is the series' answer. Its eulogies, delivered by those Dream served, wronged, created, and loved, are partial narrations that together constitute the *who* that Morpheus could not possess while alive. Cavarero's narratable self is realized posthumously and plurally: Dream becomes a story only in the mouths of others, and only once he can no longer hear it.

3.2 Scheherazade's Law: Todorov and *Worlds' End*

Tzvetan Todorov, reading the *Thousand and One Nights* ("Narrative-Men," 1971), formulated the inverse law: narration equals life, and its absence, death. Scheherazade lives as long as she narrates. *Worlds' End* (#51–56) stages this law and then reverses it. Travellers from many realities, driven by a "reality storm" into an inn that stands outside ordinary time, tell tales to pass the tempest, in a frame that recalls Boccaccio's *Decameron* (storytelling as a refuge from plague), Chaucer's *Canterbury Tales* (an inn, a company, a contest), and the *Nights* themselves. The tales nest to vertiginous depth, above all in "Cerements," where frame within frame within frame enacts what Lucien Dällenbach called *le récit spéculaire*, the narrative in abyss.

The storm, however, is no plague to be outlasted. It is the reverberation through all realities of the death of one of the Endless, and the volume closes with the travel-

lers witnessing a funeral procession across the sky. Narration in the inn does not defer death, as in Todorov's Baghdad; it witnesses it, as in Benjamin's sickroom. *The Sandman* holds both laws in tension and assigns them to different subjects: the narrator lives by narrating (Todorov); the narrated is completed by dying (Benjamin). Dream can be one or the other, Scheherazade or her subject, but the passage between the two roles is death.

3.3 Energeia and Kinesis: Death's Consolation and Solon's Dictum

In "The Sound of Her Wings" (#8), Death collects an infant who asks whether that brief span is all it gets. Death answers that it received what everyone receives: a lifetime. The reply is philosophically exact. It rejects the deprivation account of death's harm, formulated by Thomas Nagel ("Death," 1970), which measures a death against the goods a longer life would have contained, in favour of a non-comparative conception of completeness. Its positive ground is Aristotelian. In *Metaphysics* Θ.6 (1048b18–35) and *Nicomachean Ethics* X.4, Aristotle distinguishes *energeia*, activity complete at every moment (seeing, living well), from *kinesis*, movement incomplete until its end (building a house). Death speaks of life as *energeia*: a lifetime is whole at any length. The Epicurean argument (*Letter to Menoeceus* 124–127; Lucretius III.830–1094) supplies the negative ground, that death is nothing to us.

Against Death's consolation stands Solon's dictum, as Herodotus reports it to Croesus (*Histories* I.32) and Aristotle examines it (*Nicomachean Ethics* I.10): call no one happy until they are dead. Here life is *kinesis*, and its meaning is fixed only at the end. *The Sandman* holds both views and assigns each its jurisdiction: Death speaks *energeia* to the living, while narrative, the Wake, speaks *kinesis* about the dead.

The Endless are pure *energeia* without *kinesis*: complete at every moment, hence without development, hence unnarratable, hence beyond Solon's evaluation as happy or wretched. Dream's chronic melancholy, often read as temperament, is better read as an ontological longing for *kinesis*, to become something that can be finished. His death is therefore not a defeat but a completion: the conversion of an endless activity into a finished work (*ergon*). Heidegger's analysis of Being-toward-death (*Being and Time* §§46–53) is apposite with one correction. Dasein attains wholeness by anticipating its own death; Morpheus, an office whose being is generic ("one dreams," as *das Man* says "one dies"), acquires *Jemeinigkeit*, mineness, only when he acquires a death of his own. But the series corrects Heidegger through Levinas and Derrida: the meaning of that death is constituted not in solitary anticipation but in the mourning of others.

3.4 Hob Gadling and the Makropulos Problem

Hob Gadling, who in 1389 declares death a mug's game and is granted his wish (#13), is the series' laboratory for the ethics of immortality. Bernard Williams argued in "The Makropulos Case" (1973), after Čapek's play of 1922, that an endless life would exhaust the categorical desires that give a person reason to go on, collapsing character into tedium. Hob falsifies the prediction across six centuries of prosperity, ruin, bereavement, and love. After the deaths of his wife and son and the loss of his fortune, he rebuilds his wealth by trafficking enslaved Africans; when they meet in 1789, Dream warns him against the trade, and Hob afterwards leaves it. Two centuries later, in "Sunday Mourning" (#73), he confesses it with shame to his girlfriend Gwen, who is Black, apologizing until she tells him to drop the subject; and when Death visits him at a Renaissance fair, he declines to go with her. The slave trade is the decisive datum for what follows. Hob changes not only in fortune but in conscience: he was a slaver and became a man ashamed of having been one, and that moral distance, crossed within one continuous life, is what an immortal without mutability could never cross. The scene also shows the limit of the change, since his shame is closed by Gwen's forbearance rather than by any reckoning with the people he trafficked. John Martin Fischer's reply to Williams ("Why Immortality Is Not So Bad," 1994), that repeatable pleasures need not pall, has its emblem in the centennial pint at the White Horse; Kierkegaard's *Repetition* (1843), which distinguishes recollection (backward) from repetition (forward), describes the meetings themselves.

The literary comparanda map the alternatives Hob avoids: Swift's Struldbruggs (*Gulliver's Travels* III.10), immortal without youth; Tennyson's Tithonus; Simone de Beauvoir's Fosca (*All Men Are Mortal*, 1946), for whom the world loses its weight; Borges' Immortals ("The Immortal," 1947), for whom no act has value because every act will eventually be performed. Hob escapes all of these because he remains embodied, among mortals, and capable of moral change. His friendship with Dream is the comic's ethical core precisely because each lacks what the other has. Hob has development without end; Dream has endlessness without development.

The pairing yields the chapter's central claim, the **mutability thesis**: what grounds narrative selfhood is not mortality as such but mutability, of which death is the limit case. Hob is immortal and narratable because he changes; Dream is immortal and unnarratable because he cannot. "Change or die" is therefore not a disjunction but, at its limit, an identity. To change is to die a little; to die is to change entirely. Spenser's Nature had pronounced the same verdict on Mutability: things are not changed from their first estate, but by their change their being do dilate.

3.5 Idem, Ipse, and the Promise

Paul Ricoeur (*Oneself as Another*, 1990, fifth and sixth studies) distinguishes two senses of identity. *Idem* is sameness: numerical identity, qualitative similarity, and above all *character*, the set of sedimented dispositions by which a person is recognized. *Ipse* is selfhood, whose paradigm is the promise kept (*la parole tenue*), a self-constancy that persists even through change of character. Narrative identity mediates between them.

Morpheus is a case of *ipse* collapsed into *idem*. His fidelity to his word has become indistinguishable from fidelity to his nature. He keeps every bargain: the centennial appointment with Hob, the two plays commissioned from Shakespeare, the boon promised to Nuala. That last promise kills him. In *The Kindly Ones*, Nuala invokes the pendant Dream once gave her, and he leaves the protection of the Dreaming to answer her, knowing what waits outside. His death is the supreme act of *ipse*: self-constancy unto death. Yet the same event releases *idem*. Daniel inherits the office's fidelity to dreamers without Morpheus' character. The doctrine of the two bodies receives a Ricoeurian restatement: the body natural is *idem*, the body politic an impersonal *ipse*, and Morpheus could keep faith with the second only by dying as the first.

Is Daniel Morpheus? Derek Parfit (*Reasons and Persons*, 1984) argued that identity is not what matters; what matters is psychological continuity and connectedness, which come in degrees. Daniel holds a weak version of that relation: he possesses the office's knowledge and some of its memories, but not its temperament. Parfit himself cited the Buddhist precedent, and the *Milindapañha* supplies the exact formula. Asked whether the one reborn is the same as the one who died, the monk Nāgasena answers with the image of a lamp burning through the night: the flame of the last watch is neither the same as the flame of the first nor another (*na ca so na ca añño*). Daniel is neither Morpheus nor another. He is the flame passed.

3.6 Character Is Destiny: Heraclitus, Boethius, and the Garden of Forking Paths

Heraclitus' most compressed fragment (DK B119), *ēthos anthrōpōi daimōn*, holds that a person's character is their destiny. Novalis restated it (fate and disposition are names of one concept), and George Eliot qualified it in *The Mill on the Floss* (VI.6), allowing that character is destiny, but not the whole of it. *The Sandman* adopts the strong form. Destiny's book records every event, yet the series locates causation in

character: pride, rigidity, an incapacity to forgive himself, and a fidelity that has become compulsion bring Dream to his end.

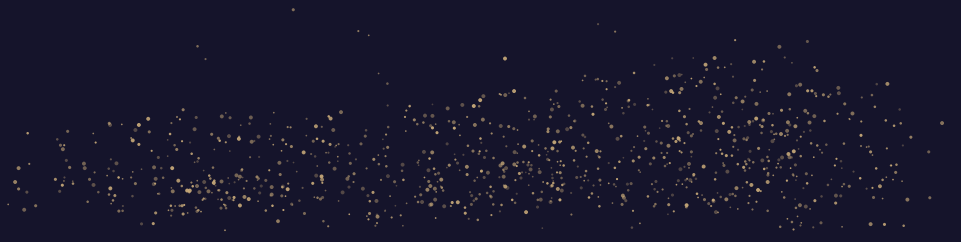
The book does not compel what it records. This is the Boethian solution (*Consolation of Philosophy* V, prose 6): eternal knowledge, beholding all times as present, imposes no necessity on the free acts it beholds. Destiny walks a garden of forking paths, the title of Borges' story of 1941, in which every possible outcome of a choice is realized in a branching time. The garden also recalls the vision with which Leibniz concludes the *Theodicy* (§§414–417): in a dream, Theodorus is led through the Palace of the Destinies, whose numberless chambers each contain a possible world, rising to the apex, which is the actual. Destiny's garden is the palace of possibilities; his book is its apex.

What the series adds is a theory of volitional constraint. Harry Frankfurt ("Freedom of the Will and the Concept of a Person," 1971; later writings on *volitional necessity*) defines persons as beings with second-order volitions, desires about which desires should move them, and observes that there are things a person cannot bring themselves to will. Dream has a second-order volition to be other than he is, and no means to make it effective while he remains himself. His death is the only form in which that volition can take effect. It is a choice in the sense of Luther's declaration that he could do no other: an act free precisely because it issues from the whole character of the one who performs it.

IV

The Political Theology of Abdication

The Sandman *is a treatise on sovereignty whose recurring exemplary act is renunciation; it holds that abdication does not abolish power but relocates it, and that the ethics of an abdication depend entirely on where the power goes.*



4.1 Decision, Inoperativity, Mourning: Three Theories of the Sovereign

Carl Schmitt's *Political Theology* (1922) opens with the definition that the sovereign is the one who decides on the exception. Dream decides on exceptions throughout: he releases Nada from a sentence he himself imposed; he disposes of the key to Hell; he kills his son Orpheus, whom Death had exempted from her domain. But the series' supreme sovereign act is one Schmitt did not foresee, the **autothanatic decision**: the sovereign's decision on the exception of his own continuance. Schmitt's sovereign suspends the law to preserve the order; Dream suspends himself to preserve the office.

Giorgio Agamben's *The Kingdom and the Glory* (2007) supplies the countermodel. Western power, Agamben argues, is bipolar, divided between a reign that does not govern and a government that does not reign, and its inmost emblem is the empty throne (*hetoimasia*) of Byzantine iconography. Destruction's abandoned realm is such a throne. After 1695, destruction continues by pure economy, without a sovereign, which is Agamben's thesis made literal. The Dreaming, by contrast, cannot be governed by economy alone: *Preludes & Nocturnes* shows it falling into ruin in its master's absence. That is why the Dreaming requires a succession rather than a vacancy.

Benjamin's *Origin of the German Mourning Play* (1928) supplies the affect. The baroque sovereign of the *Trauerspiel* is a melancholic, paralyzed between tyranny and martyrdom, holding history in his hand like a sceptre; the genre ends in corpses that are converted into allegories. Morpheus, who sulks through the first volumes and whose realm rains when he grieves, is a sovereign of this kind, and *The Wake*, which displays the dead king's body as the occasion for stories, is a mourning play in Benjamin's exact sense. Benjamin opposed the *Trauerspiel* (historical, creaturely, melancholic) to Greek tragedy (mythic, sacrificial, communal). *The Sandman* fuses them: Dream dies a tragic death at the hands of the Furies inside a world built as a mourning play.

4.2 Lucifer's Resignation and the Penal Reform of Hell

In *Season of Mists* (#21–28), Lucifer empties Hell, expels its demons and damned, locks its gates, has Dream cut off his wings, and hands Dream the key. Milton's Satan had declared that the mind is its own place, able to make a Heaven of Hell, and that it is better to reign in Hell than serve in Heaven (*Paradise Lost* I.254–263). Gaiman's Lucifer rejects both terms of the alternative and invents a third: he will neither reign nor serve, but resign. His stated grievance is that he is blamed for

choices humans make themselves, and that the damned arrive because they believe they deserve punishment. The theology here is Swedenborg's (*Heaven and Hell*, 1758), in which God casts no one into Hell and spirits gravitate there by their ruling love, and C. S. Lewis's (*The Great Divorce*, 1945), in which the doors of Hell are locked from the inside. Blake's *Marriage of Heaven and Hell* (c. 1790) lends the sympathy: Gaiman's Lucifer is of the Devil's party and knows it.

The abdication's aftermath is the series' sharpest political lesson. Dream returns the key to the Silver City, and the angels Remiel and Duma are assigned against their will to administer Hell. Remiel's regime replaces retribution with correction: the damned will suffer for their own good, until they improve. Lewis had diagnosed exactly this in "The Humanitarian Theory of Punishment" (1949), arguing that to detach punishment from desert and recast it as cure removes every limit on its duration and every dignity from its object. Michel Foucault's *Discipline and Punish* (1975) traced the historical passage from the spectacle of torture to the timetable of correction. Gaiman's angelic Hell is the Foucauldian moment in eschatology. Its horror lies in Remiel's sincerity.

The episode yields the governing principle of the chapter. **Abdication relocates sovereignty and can intensify it.** Lucifer's freedom is purchased by the transfer of his burden; the transfer produces a reformatory Hell arguably worse than the punitive one. The series discriminates among abdications by their destination: Destruction's succeeds because his function is self-executing; Lucifer's issues in a humanitarian tyranny; Dream's succeeds because it is a succession to a designated heir, not a vacancy.

4.3 Emperors of Limit: Augustus, Harun al-Rashid, Joshua Norton, Prospero

The single-issue stories gathered in *Fables & Reflections* constitute a mirror for princes.

- **Augustus** ("August," #30) spends one day a year disguised as a beggar, accompanied by the actor Lycius, in order to plan beyond the sight of the gods. The story takes up the charge, recorded by Suetonius as Mark Antony's, that the young Octavian earned his adoption by submitting sexually to Julius Caesar (*Augustus* 68), and turns on a decision documented by Tacitus: Augustus' posthumous counsel that the empire be kept within its boundaries (*consilium coercendi intra terminos imperii*, *Annals* I.11). Virgil's Jupiter had promised Rome an empire without end (*imperium sine fine*, *Aeneid* I.278–279). Gaiman's Augustus countersigns Tacitus against Virgil: the founder chooses finitude for his

creation. Gaiman turns the slander into testimony: in flashback, the story shows Caesar repeatedly raping the young Augustus, who did not resist because Caesar had promised to adopt him as his heir, and the grown emperor tells Lycius that he hated him. Succession here is purchased through the abuse of the heir, and the founder's choice of finitude is therefore not serene renunciation. Caesar has been made a god, and Augustus spends his one unobserved day each year planning, out of the gods' sight, the limits that will in time bring Rome down, as revenge on the man who abused him. He is Dream's precursor, a sovereign who designs the mortality of what he rules, and his case establishes that the abdications this chapter traces can issue from injury as well as from wisdom.

- **Harun al-Rashid** ("Ramadan," #50) fears the decline of Baghdad at its zenith and sells the city to Dream, who preserves its legendary form in the Dreaming while the historical city becomes ordinary. The bargain is Goethe's wager reversed. Faust forfeits his soul if he ever bids the passing moment stay, for it is so fair (*Verweile doch! du bist so schön!*, *Faust* I, 1700); Harun asks exactly that, and pays with his real city. He converts his realm from the mortal mode to the diegetic, the descent of one rung that Morpheus himself will later make. Chapter Five examines the issue's Orientalist double edge.
- **Joshua Norton** ("Three Septembers and a January," #31) inverts the pattern by assuming a sovereignty he does not possess, and is saved from Despair by it. Lacan's late punning title, *Les non-dupes errent* (Seminar XXI, 1973–74), names the lesson: those who refuse to be duped go astray. Norton, duped by his own fiction and supported by a city willing to share it, does not.
- **Prospero** is the paradigm the series reserves for its end. Dream commissions *The Tempest* because it dramatizes the renunciation he cannot perform: the magician who abjures his rough magic and resolves to drown his book (V.i.50–57), and who in the Epilogue asks the audience to release him from his bands.

4.4 The Wounded King, the Divine King, and the Orphic Structure

Preludes & Nocturnes is a Fisher King narrative. While the king is captive, the land is waste: the Dreaming decays and the waking world falls into sleepy sickness. Jessie Weston's *From Ritual to Romance* (1920) and T. S. Eliot's *The Waste Land* (1922) made this structure the defining myth of modernist crisis; *The Sandman* begins where *The Waste Land* ends, with the king restored and the land beginning to heal.

The Kindly Ones completes the Frazerian cycle. *The Golden Bough* (3rd edition, Part III, *The Dying God*, 1911) argued that divine kings were killed before their

powers waned, so that the divine spirit might pass undiminished to a vigorous successor; its emblem is the priest-king of Nemi, slain by the one who replaces him. Morpheus is the exhausted king (*Overture* retroactively explains the exhaustion), the Furies are his slayers, and Daniel is the vigorous successor. Wittgenstein's "Remarks on Frazer's *Golden Bough*" (written 1931) objected that Frazer misread such rites as mistaken science rather than expressive acts. *The Sandman* reads ritual as Wittgenstein would: *The Wake* does not cause the succession; it expresses it.

The final arc also has an Orphic structure that has gone largely unremarked. In the received myth, Orpheus is the son of Calliope by Apollo or by Oeagrus. Gaiman makes his father Dream. The substitution literalizes the first section of Nietzsche's *Birth of Tragedy* (1872), which identifies the Apollonian principle with dream, the realm of beautiful illusion and individuation, and the Dionysian with intoxication, which dissolves the individual. Orpheus, the son of the Apollonian Dream, is torn apart by the Bacchantes, the votaries of Dionysus (*Metamorphoses* XI.1–66), and his severed head goes on singing. Dream's own death repeats this *sparagmos* at cosmic scale: the Furies, chthonic and frenzied, tear through the Dreaming. Then comes rebirth from ordeal. Daniel's abduction by Loki and Puck and his passage through fire, which persuades his mother he is dead, recall Demeter's nightly burning away of the infant Demophon's mortality (*Homeric Hymn to Demeter* 231–255) and the Orphic Zagreus, the divine child torn apart and reborn. The sequence (Apollonian sovereign, Dionysian dismemberment, reborn divine child) is an Orphic theogony; *The Kindly Ones* is the birth of tragedy out of the spirit of the comic book.

Brief Lives (#41–49) is the preparatory movement. Dream travels with Delirium, formerly Delight, his Dionysian sister, in search of their brother. Nietzsche held that the summit of tragedy is reached when Dionysus speaks the language of Apollo and Apollo, finally, the language of Dionysus (*Birth of Tragedy* §21). *Brief Lives* is that exchange conducted as a road narrative, and at its end the Apollonian brother does the Dionysian thing: he spills his own son's blood.

4.5 Kenosis: Incarnation, Answer, Sacrifice

The Letter to the Philippians says that Christ, being in the form of God, emptied himself (*heauton ekenōsen*), taking the form of a servant (2:6–8). Kenotic theology made this self-emptying the hinge of incarnation; Kierkegaard's *Philosophical Fragments* (1844) gave it a parable. A king who loves a humble maiden cannot elevate her without making his love a condescension; he must descend and appear as a servant. In *Death: The High Cost of Living* (1993), Death takes mortal form for one day each century, so that the power that ends lives may know what it is to live one. She is the

series' exemplary kenotic Endless. Morpheus completes the movement she prefigures: he empties the office into a successor of human birth.

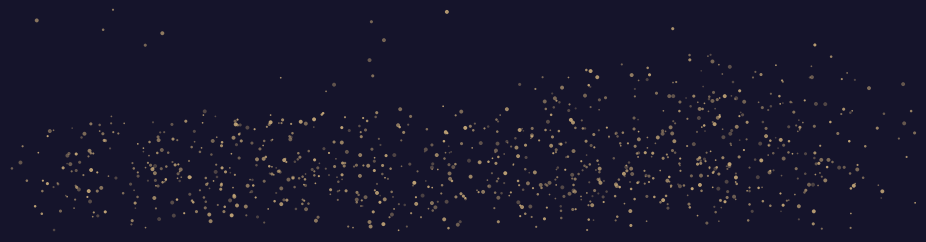
Jung's *Answer to Job* (1952) supplies the theological logic. Confronted by Job's integrity, Yahweh is revealed as an archetype without moral self-consciousness, who must become human in order to become just. Nada is Dream's Job. A mortal queen who loved him and refused him, condemned by him to ten thousand years in Hell (#9), she becomes, at the family gathering of *Season of Mists*, the occasion of his first moral recognition, forced upon him by his siblings. His succession by Daniel, a child conceived in the Dreaming but born of mortal parents and named for the biblical interpreter of dreams, is Jung's incarnation in oneiric form: the archetype becomes moral by becoming, in part, human.

René Girard's *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) describes the sacrificial crisis in which reciprocal vengeance spreads until it is discharged onto a single victim, whose misrecognized death restores order. Lyta's vengeance is mimetic reciprocity (her son for his son), and the Furies are its executors. Dream breaks the cycle not as an unwitting scapegoat but as a consenting victim, and the new Dream's first act toward Lyta is protection rather than retaliation. Aeschylus resolved the Furies by law, in Athena's court; Gaiman resolves them by kenosis. Gianni Vattimo's account of secularization as the kenotic weakening of the violent sacred (*Belief*, 1996) names the historical direction: the Dream-office passes from a strong sovereign to a gentler one. Harold Bloom's third revisionary ratio, also called *kenosis* (*The Anxiety of Influence*, 1973), names the same movement in literary-historical terms. The latecomer empties himself of the precursor's afflatus and, in doing so, empties the precursor. Daniel stands thus to Morpheus, and Gaiman's Sandman to the Sandmen of Fox and Kirby.

V

The Ethics of Release and Its Limits

Dream's moral education proceeds through a grammar of captivity and release, and that grammar, however humane its outcomes, remains a grammar of sovereignty whose costs fall disproportionately on women and on those the realm cannot hold.



5.1 Captivity as Primal Scene

The series opens with a god in a glass sphere and closes with a magician asking an audience to set him free. Between these brackets, captivity is the most frequent structural situation in the work: Calliope held captive for decades by Erasmus Fry and then raped by Richard Madoc; Nada held in Hell under Dream's own sentence; Jed Walker, a child, locked in a cellar and abused by the relatives who had custody of him, while Brute and Glob walled off a counterfeit dream inside his sleeping mind; Lyta Hall kept for nearly two years inside that counterfeit dream, her pregnancy suspended; Orpheus' head confined to undying life; Lucifer imprisoned by his own office; Baghdad sealed in a bottle; Loki chained beneath the serpent until Dream frees him and leaves a dream in his place.

Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage (*Phenomenology of Spirit*, §§178–196) describes the first transformation. Roderick Burgess is lord and Dream bondsman; the lord's dependence on the captive is total, and the bondsman's fear becomes, in Hegel's account, the beginning of wisdom. Dream's first response on release, however, is the lord's, not the bondsman's: he condemns Alex Burgess to eternal waking. His moral history is the slow conversion of that response.

Calderón's *La vida es sueño* (1635) supplies its trajectory. Segismundo, imprisoned in a tower by a father who feared a prophecy, is released, rages, is drugged and returned, and told that his liberty was a dream. He concludes that life is a dream and that, even in dreams, the doing of good is not lost (*que aun en sueños / no se pierde el hacer bien*); he pardons his father and rules justly. Dream's arc follows the same three stages: captivity, violent release, and the recognition that a being who is himself a dream must still act well. In "The Sound of Her Wings" (#8), Death rebukes her brother's self-pity and walks him through a day of endings; the scene is Boethian, a despondent prisoner consoled by a feminine personification who teaches him the nature of fortune and finitude.

5.2 The Grammar of Release: Nada, Calliope, Orpheus

Three releases structure Dream's development, and each carries a characteristic asymmetry.

Nada (#9; *Season of Mists*). A queen who loved Dream, she refused him on learning what he was, because a mortal's union with one of the Endless was forbidden and would bring ruin. When she yielded to him, the ruin came: the Sun, judging the union, destroyed her city of glass and killed its people, and Nada, holding herself responsible, took her own life. Dream came to her in the realm of the dead and asked her again to be his queen; when she refused, he condemned her to Hell, where she

remained for ten thousand years. Her injuries are therefore three, and the last is his alone: her people killed, her death by her own hand, and ten millennia of torment imposed by the lover she had refused. Desire and Despair later allude to a failed scheme against Dream that had turned on Nada (#10), so that her love itself may have been an instrument of the Endless' quarrels. Rebuked by his family, Dream descends to free her, and she chooses rebirth. The release redresses the releaser's own crime, which structurally centres his moral growth rather than her injury: she is a station in his *Bildung*. The issue's frame is unusually self-aware. The tale is told by a grandfather to a boy at a men's rite, and the story closes by noting that the women tell it differently. The series marks its own partiality; marking it does not undo it.

Calliope (#17). The eldest Muse is captured by the ageing writer Erasmus Fry and sold to the blocked novelist Richard Madoc in exchange for a trichobezoar, a hairball, an object of grotesque materiality that functions as the commodity form of inspiration. Madoc rapes her and becomes successful. Freed from his own captivity, Dream punishes Madoc with a deluge of ideas that drives him to scrawl them in his own blood, then releases both. The story is the series' most explicit indictment of literary production as extraction, in which the Muse is a resource and the author a proprietor. Its punishment is a Dantean *contrapasso* (an excess of the very good that was stolen). The asymmetry here is generic as well as moral: Calliope's liberation, like Nada's, is accomplished by a man whose prior abandonment of her is also part of the story. As noted in the Introduction, "Calliope" cannot now be read outside its author's reception; its analytical resources remain intact.

Orpheus (*The Sandman Special* #1; *Brief Lives*). When Eurydice dies, Dream refuses his son's plea for help, and Death grants Orpheus passage to the underworld on condition that she will not later take him. Torn apart by the Bacchantes, Orpheus survives as a singing head for millennia. In *Brief Lives*, Dream finally grants what he once refused: he kills his son, at his son's request. Kierkegaard's *Fear and Trembling* (1843) offers the inverted analogue. Abraham, prepared to sacrifice Isaac on command, is stayed and receives his son back; Dream acts on the son's request, is not stayed, and is condemned for it, since the mercy is juridically kin-slaying and brings the Kindly Ones within their right. Kierkegaard distinguished the *knight of infinite resignation*, who renounces the finite and finds peace in that renunciation, from the *knight of faith*, who renounces it and receives it back. Morpheus is the first; the receiving-back is transferred to his successor and his realm. *The Sandman* is a narrative of infinite resignation whose faith is distributed.

5.3 The Muse and the Market: Faustian Bargains

Shakespeare's bargain is the series' extended meditation on the cost of genius. In 1589, at the White Horse, the young Will envies Marlowe and asks for the gift of his dreams; Dream grants it in exchange for two plays celebrating dreams (#13). *A Midsummer Night's Dream* is performed for the court of Faerie in 1593 (#19), where Hamnet confides that his father cares more for his stories than for him. Hamnet died in 1596. *The Tempest* completes the contract (#75).

The bargain inherits the Faust tradition: Marlowe's *Doctor Faustus* (c. 1592), in which the pact ends in damnation, and Goethe's *Faust* (1808/1832), in which striving is redeemed. Its nearest structural analogue is Thomas Mann's *Doktor Faustus* (1947). Adrian Leverkühn purchases twenty-four years of creative genius on condition that he may not love; when he loves his small nephew Nepomuk, called Echo, the child dies of meningitis. In both works, genius is bought and a child pays. Harold Bloom's thesis that Shakespeare invented the modern human interiority (*Shakespeare: The Invention of the Human*, 1998) appears in *The Sandman* a decade earlier as myth: Shakespeare supplies the dreams of modernity because Dream supplied Shakespeare. The series celebrates the gift and indicts the price, and does not resolve the two.

5.4 The Oresteian Remainder

The Kindly Ones is a rewriting of the *Oresteia* (458 BCE). Orestes' matricide summons the Erinyes; Apollo defends him; Athena convenes a court, casts the deciding vote, and transforms the Furies into the Eumenides, the "Kindly Ones," with a cult beneath the city. In Gaiman's version, Dream's filicide brings the Furies within their jurisdiction; they are summoned by Lyta Hall, whose prior identity in DC continuity was the superheroine Fury; and no Athena intervenes. The series' title retains the Aeschylean euphemism as irony: the Kindly Ones remain Furies.

Froma Zeitlin's "The Dynamics of Misogyny: Myth and Mythmaking in the *Oresteia*" (1978) showed that the trilogy's settlement rests on Apollo's argument that the mother is not the true parent of the child, only the nurse of the seed (*Eumenides* 657–666), endorsed by Athena, born of a father alone. *The Sandman* reprises the argument. In *The Doll's House*, Dream finds Lyta Hall living inside a counterfeit dream walled off by the renegade dreams Brute and Glob, with the ghost of her dead husband, Hector Hall, whom they had installed there as a false Sandman; her pregnancy has been suspended for nearly two years. Dream sends Hector's ghost on to the realm of the dead, returns Lyta alone to the waking world, and tells her that the

child she carries, conceived and gestated within the Dreaming, is his, and that he will come for it. Lyta's grievance therefore has two counts before the endgame begins: her husband's ghost sent away and her child claimed. When Loki and Puck abduct Daniel and leave her believing him dead, she holds Dream responsible, and her maternal claim turns upon the paternal one and destroys its bearer. Yet the denouement fulfils the claim posthumously: Daniel becomes Dream, and the mother loses her child to the very office she has destroyed. The new Dream extends his protection to her; the gesture is an acknowledgment and a re-appropriation at once.

I call this the **Oresteian remainder**: the residue of injustice that the series' consolatory structure does not metabolize. Maternal grievance is absorbed into paternal succession. The remainder is not confined to Lyta. Across the series, women's bodies are made the instruments of the Endless' quarrels or the price of male creation: Unity Kinkaid raped in her sleep by Desire to set a trap for Dream; Nada condemned to Hell by Dream for refusing him; Calliope held captive by one writer and raped by another; Lyta's husband sent into death and her child claimed. The "kindly" resolution is kind to the office, not to the mother. The text knows this, and *The Wake* lingers on Lyta's desolation, but knowledge is not redress.

5.5 Bodies the Dream Cannot Hold

A Game of You (#32–37) presses the limit from another direction. Barbie's childhood dream-kingdom, the Land, threatened by the parasitic Cuckoo, is a Winnicottian transitional world whose dissolution is maturation. Around it, the women of a New York apartment building are drawn into the crisis, among them Wanda, a trans woman, and Thessaly, a witch of ancient Thessaly, the region whose women were proverbially said to draw down the moon (Plato, *Gorgias* 513a; Aristophanes, *Clouds* 749–752). The Moon's magic, as Thessaly administers it, excludes Wanda by an essentialist criterion of sex: Thessaly bars her from the Moon's road on the ground that, in the Moon's reckoning, she is not a woman, and Wanda stays behind. Thessaly's drawing down of the moon raises a storm over the city, and the storm kills Wanda. Her parents cut off her long hair and bury her under the name she had abandoned; after the funeral, Barbie writes Wanda's name over it on the headstone in Wanda's own lipstick; in Barbie's dream, Wanda appears beside Death as herself.

The arc dramatizes a conflict between two ontologies. The Moon's ritual is essentialist; the series' own ladder of persistence is narrative, holding that beings are what they are dreamt and told as. Death, the final authority of finitude, recognizes Wanda as she is; the Moon does not. Yet the recognition arrives only posthumously and in dream. Wanda becomes fully real in the diegetic mode after expulsion from the mor-

tal one. The structure mirrors Dream's own (narratability purchased by death) but distributes it unjustly: the sovereign chooses his death; Wanda does not, and the rite that refused to recognize her raised the storm that killed her. The essentialism the arc diagnoses does not merely exclude; in this plot it kills. Critics have identified in the arc a familiar pattern by which trans and queer characters are killed so that their dignity may be affirmed in elegy; the reading proposed here holds that *A Game of You* both diagnoses the essentialism and reproduces the elegiac pattern.

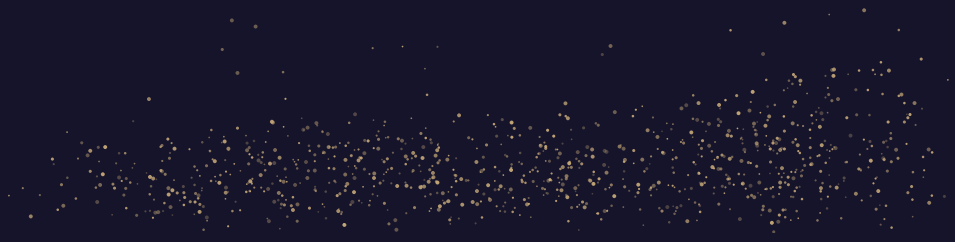
"Ramadan" (#50) exhibits the same double edge in a postcolonial register. It was published in 1993, two years after a United States–led coalition bombed Iraq, Baghdad included, in the air campaign of January and February 1991, and its frame shows a boy in the war-damaged streets of modern Baghdad, setting the legendary city of the *Nights* against the city those bombs had struck. Read through Edward Said's *Orientalism* (1978), the bargain risks sanctioning a familiar preference for the Baghdad of Western fantasy over the city of living Iraqis, a risk sharpened by the fact that the fantasy was published by an American company in the aftermath of an American-led war; read through its frame, it offers the boy a story in which his city is imperishable. The issue holds both readings and resolves neither.

The synthesis is a limit. Dream's ethics of release remain aristocratic: magnanimity is an exercise of sovereignty, and the series never imagines the abolition of the Dreaming's monarchy, only the change of its monarch. Philip Pullman's *His Dark Materials* ends with a frail Authority released from his crystal litter and dissolving with relief, and a Republic of Heaven proposed in place of the Kingdom; Le Guin's *The Dispossessed* (1974) imagines an anarchist society without sovereign. *The Sandman*'s political horizon is a constitutional monarchy of the imagination, reformed by succession. That is its achievement and its boundary.

VI

Exiting the Oneiric Climate

The doctrine that a function can become a self only by dying is enacted by the work's form: The Sandman *ends, and in ending it escapes the dream-time of serial comics, a time to which its institutional afterlife has since returned it.*



6.1 Eco's Superman and the Iterative Scheme

In "The Myth of Superman" (Italian 1962; English 1972), Umberto Eco identified the paradox of the serial superhero. As a mythic figure, the hero must be immutable; as the protagonist of a novelistic narrative, he must act, and action consumes him: it ages him, binds him, moves him toward death. The serial resolves the paradox through what Eco called an **oneiric climate** (*clima onirico*), a hazy temporality in which before and after dissolve, each episode begins anew, and the iterative scheme guarantees that nothing irreversible occurs. Superman cannot marry, age, or die, because any such event would consume him.

Eco's term is a diagnosis that *The Sandman* converts into a character. Morpheus is the oneiric climate personified: immutable, iterative, ageless, endless. The Endless are, in a precise sense, the metaphysics of the serial character, beings who persist by refusing to be consumed. The series' decision to end, and to end with its protagonist's death, is therefore not only a narrative event but a formal emancipation. In a publishing economy whose value lies in perpetual middles, *The Sandman* introduces consumption. Frank Kermode's *The Sense of an Ending* (1967) argued that fictions confer meaning by organizing time toward an end, converting the successive time of *chronos* into the charged time of *kairos*; Peter Brooks's *Reading for the Plot* (1984), reading Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle*, described plot as a detour toward an end that retroactively shapes it. Both describe what happens to *The Sandman* at #69. The anthology issues of *Dream Country*, *Fables & Reflections*, and *Worlds' End*, which once read as interludes, are revealed as detours on a single road; Dream's claim upon Lyta's unborn child in *The Doll's House* becomes, in retrospect, the first move of the endgame. Retroactive ontogenesis, the cats' doctrine, operates at the level of the whole work.

The imperative "change or die" is thus also the medium's. A serial comic can change, becoming a finished work, or it can persist without meaning. *The Sandman* changes by dying.

6.2 The Gutter as Dreaming: Closure, Braiding, and the Two Bodies of the Book

Scott McCloud's *Understanding Comics* (1993) named the reader's activity between panels *closure*: the gutter shows nothing, and the reader supplies what happens there. In *The Sandman*, the gutter is the Dreaming. The reader's work across the empty space between images is the Heraclitean labour of sleepers (B75); every reader is a co-worker in what the comic comes to be. The homology between the medium's ontology (meaning produced by the reader's imagination in the gaps) and the

Dreaming's (reality produced by the collective imagination of sleepers) is the deepest formal fact about the work.

Thierry Groensteen's *System of Comics* (1999) calls the network of correspondences that link non-adjacent panels across a work *braiding* (*tressage*). The series is braided by a small set of recurring figures, each of which carries a strand of its argument:

- **The sphere**: Dream's glass prison, the bottled Baghdad of "Ramadan," and the realms sealed in miniature, figures of preservation as captivity.
- **The eye**: the Corinthian's devouring mouths, Destiny's blindness, Dream's star-like pupils, Unity's sleeping lids, the Hoffmannian thread of sight and its loss.
- **Sand and dust**: the matter of Dream's pouch and the matter of the grave, binding Sleep to Death as Genesis 3:19 binds dust to mortality.
- **The raven**: the bird of carrion and prophecy, from Matthew's arrival to his choice to stay with the new Dream.

Charles Hatfield's *Alternative Comics* (2005) describes the tension in comics between the text as experience and the text as object. *The Sandman* adds a further tension, between two material forms of itself. The monthly issue is dated, consumed, and disposable: a body natural. The collected volume, shelved in bookstores and libraries, later canonized in deluxe editions, is a body politic. The series was among the works that carried comics from the newsstand into the bookshop in the early 1990s; its own publication history performs the doctrine of the two bodies.

The artists of the closing arcs complete the formal argument. Marc Hempel's flat, angular abstraction in *The Kindly Ones* renders the Dreaming's dismemberment as the dismemberment of form; Michael Zulli's dense naturalism in *The Wake* restores weight, the materiality of mourning. Charles Vess drew both Shakespearean issues (#19 and #75), so that the bargain is bookended by a single hand.

6.3 Wake and *Erwachen*

The title of the final volume carries three senses: the vigil kept over the dead, the act of waking, and the trace a vessel leaves on water. James Joyce's *Finnegans Wake* (1939), the twentieth century's great night-book, borrows its title from a ballad in which the hod-carrier Tim Finnegan, laid out for dead, revives when whiskey, the water of life, splashes on his corpse; its final sentence runs back into its first in a Vichian *ricorso* (Vico, *Scienza nuova*, 1725/1744). *The Wake* is circular in the same way. The funeral of one Dream is the investiture of the next; the end runs into a beginning.

Walter Benjamin's *Arcades Project* (1927–40) supplies the political sense of awakening. Benjamin treated the nineteenth century as a collective dream and the dialectical moment of historical knowledge as an awakening (*Erwachen*), in which the present recognizes the dream from which it comes. He took as epigraph Michelet's sentence that every epoch dreams the one that follows ("Paris, Capital of the Nineteenth Century," 1935). The sentence describes *The Sandman*'s succession literally: Daniel was dreamt into being, gestated within the Dreaming, by the epoch he succeeds. *The Wake* is the medium's Benjaminian awakening, the moment in which the comic book recognizes its oneiric climate as a dream and wakes from it over the body of the dream's personification.

6.4 Franchise Phantasmagoria

Awakening, in Benjamin, is precarious. The commodity world reasserts itself as *phantasmagoria*, a dream-image that masks its conditions of production. *The Sandman*'s afterlife follows this course: the spin-off series *The Dreaming* (1996–2001), the *Sandman Universe* line (from 2018), an audio drama, and a television adaptation (2022–2025) have returned Morpheus to circulation. The most revealing instance is authorial. *Overture* (2013–15), written by Gaiman himself, returns to the dead king's past. The prequel is the serial's characteristic revenge on an ending, readmitting the oneiric climate through the door of *before*. Joyce's ballad supplies the comic image: Finnegan rises whenever the whiskey of capital splashes the corpse.

The juridical substrate is exact. Under work-for-hire arrangements, the character belongs to a corporation, and the corporation is the legal body politic of the fiction. *The Sandman* theorized a dignity that does not die and was published under a regime that makes its own protagonist precisely such a dignity, a corporation sole in fact as well as figure. Its doctrine explains its fate.

6.5 The Two Bodies of the Author

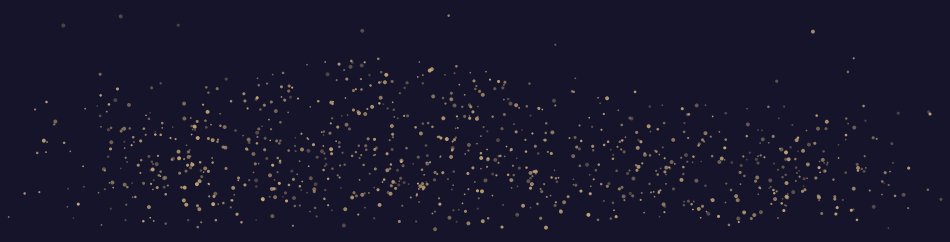
Roland Barthes's "The Death of the Author" (1967) proposed that the birth of the reader must be paid for by the death of the Author; Michel Foucault's "What Is an Author?" (1969) redescribed the author as a function, a principle by which a culture classifies and limits the proliferation of meaning. *The Sandman* literalizes both. The Prince of Stories dies; the Dreaming continues; the function survives the person. Yet the work refuses the alibi these theories have sometimes been made to supply. "Calliope" and the Shakespearean issues insist that authors are morally answerable for what their art extracts from others and for whom it costs.

Since 2024, the reception of the work has been reorganized by the allegations set out in the Introduction: that its author raped, sexually assaulted, or coerced women, among them a young woman employed as a nanny in his household. He denies them; his lawyers have told a court that New Zealand police found the nanny's complaint meritless; and her suits in the United States ended on forum grounds without a ruling on their merits. Readers have asked whether the work survives its author, and the question has commonly been framed as a choice between separation and contamination. The doctrine reconstructed in this thesis suggests a third description. A work, like the office of Dream, has two bodies. Its body natural is bound to the person who made it and shares that person's history; its body politic is constituted by the community of its readers, the commons of those who have dreamt it, and by the institutions that hold it. The series' own account of succession is that the body politic survives the body natural only at the price of mourning, never of amnesia: the king mourned in *The Wake* is the king the reader has watched condemn Nada to ten thousand years in Hell for refusing him, refuse his son's plea for help, and at last kill that son at his request. Whatever the adjudication of the claims, the critical resources the work supplies, its analysis of extraction, captivity, and the ownership of muses, belong to its body politic and may be turned against any author, its own included. "Calliope" is the work's own indictment of the relation alleged against its maker, and the indictment does not lapse because the accused wrote it. Harold Bloom named the last of his revisionary ratios *apophrades*, after the Athenian days on which the dead return to the houses they once inhabited. *The Sandman*'s afterlives, adaptive and critical alike, are apophrades in that sense: the dead returning, and the living deciding on what terms to receive them.

VII

The Commonwealth of Fabulation

Set among the speculative and philosophical fictions with which it shares its problems, The Sandman *is distinguished less by its themes than by its settlement: it alone makes the sovereign of fiction mortal while keeping the sovereignty of fiction intact.*



Work	Shared problem	*The Sandman*'s divergence
Borges, "The Circular Ruins" (1940)	A dreamer who is himself dreamt	The dreamt sovereign gains selfhood by dying, not by discovering he is a phantom
Borges, "Everything and Nothing" (1960)	Shakespeare and God as "many and no one"	The empty sovereign asks the poet for a story rather than confessing his emptiness
Le Guin, *The Lathe of Heaven* (1971)	Dreams that rewrite reality	Collective dreaming as polity rather than individual affliction
Le Guin, *The Farthest Shore* (1972)	Refusing death breaks the world	The refusal of change, not of death, is the fault
Pullman, *His Dark Materials* (1995–2000)	A frail sovereign of the cosmos	Monarchy reformed by succession, not abolished for a republic
Pratchett, *Small Gods* (1992), *Hogfather* (1996)	Gods sustained by belief; necessary fictions	Adds an officiary tier the Discworld does not systematize
Willingham, *Fables* (2002–15)	Fictional vitality as popularity	Persistence by function and mourning, not by fame
Kafka, "On Parables" (posth.)	Becoming a parable	The protagonist follows the parable to its end

7.1 Borges and Calvino

In "The Circular Ruins" (1940), a man dreams a son, organ by organ, into existence; the dreamt son can walk through fire unharmed, because he is a phantom; at the end, fire engulfs the dreamer, and he learns, without pain, that he too is being dreamt. Daniel's ordeal by fire in *The Kindly Ones* reads as a citation in reverse. The flame that does not consume is the sign of oneiric nature, and Daniel emerges from it as Dream. The divergence is decisive. Borges' dreamer discovers his unreality and accepts it with humiliation and relief; Gaiman's dreamer chooses his ending and becomes, by it, more real.

Borges' parable "Everything and Nothing" (in *El hacedor*, 1960) is the nearest philosophical analogue to #75 in world literature. Shakespeare, a man with no self, becomes everyone in his plays; dying, he asks God to let him be one man, himself. God answers that He too is no one, that He dreamt the world as Shakespeare dreamt his work, and that Shakespeare, among the forms of His dream, is like Him many and no one. Both writers pair Shakespeare with a sovereign who is empty of self. Borges theologizes the emptiness: it is the shared condition of creators. Gaiman narrativizes its cure: Dream asks Shakespeare for the story he lacks and then acquires it by dying. Borges' Library of Babel (1941), containing every possible book, is likewise the foil to Lucien's library of dreamt-actual books (Chapter One).

Italo Calvino's *Invisible Cities* (1972) has Marco Polo describe to Kublai Khan cities that are all, finally, versions of Venice; its last passage counsels seeking out,

amid the inferno of the living, what is not inferno, and giving it space to endure. "Soft Places" (#39) places Polo in a desert where waking and dream bleed together, and pairs him with Rustichello of Pisa, who in 1298 would take down Polo's book in a Genoese prison. Here, too, the book is born in captivity. Calvino's counsel of preservation is the ethics of "Ramadan" stated without its Faustian price.

7.2 Le Guin, Pullman, Pratchett

Le Guin's *The Lathe of Heaven* (1971), whose title and epigraphs come from Zhuangzi, gives George Orr effective dreams and sets against him the psychiatrist Haber, who uses them to engineer a better world with escalating catastrophe. Haber is a utilitarian John Dee. Orr's Daoist passivity is the virtue Morpheus lacks and Daniel may possess: the *Daodejing* holds that the stiff and unbending are companions of death and the soft and yielding companions of life (ch. 76), which is the entire moral structure of *The Sandman* in a sentence. Zhuangzi's dream of the butterfly (*Zhuangzi* ch. 2), which ends with the phrase "the transformation of things" (*wuhua*), supplies the metaphysics: identity is a moment in transformation. In *The Farthest Shore* (1972), the sorcerer Cob's refusal of death opens a breach through which life drains from the world, and Ged spends all his power to close it, returning home an ordinary man. Ged is a Prospero who completes the renunciation. Le Guin locates the fault in the refusal of death; Gaiman, as Chapter Three argued, locates it in the refusal of change.

Philip Pullman's *His Dark Materials* stages, in *The Amber Spyglass* (2000), the death of the Authority, an ancient angel who claimed to be creator, released from a crystal litter and dissolving with something like relief. The image unites Dream's glass prison and the release-into-death of Orpheus. Pullman's harpies in the land of the dead accept true stories of the dead's lives as payment for guiding them out, so that narrative becomes the currency of liberation. Where Pullman privileges true stories over lies, Gaiman insists on the truth of tales that never happened; where Pullman abolishes the Kingdom of Heaven for a Republic, Gaiman reforms the monarchy of dream by succession.

Terry Pratchett, Gaiman's collaborator on *Good Omens* (1990), developed in the Discworld the nearest sibling theology. In *Small Gods* (1992), a god's power is proportional to the number of his believers, and the great god Om is reduced to a tortoise with one. In *Reaper Man* (1991), Death is forced into mortality and learns, as a farmhand, what it is to have time; Gaiman's Death takes a mortal day every century in *The High Cost of Living* two years later. In *Hogfather* (1996), Death argues that humans must learn to believe small fictions so that they can believe the large

ones (justice, mercy) that have no more physical existence. The argument is *The Sandman*'s defence of fiction in its most compressed form. What Pratchett does not systematize is the officiary tier: the Discworld's personifications are characters, not offices, and no Discworld Death dies to be succeeded.

7.3 Dreamlands: Dunsany, Lovecraft, Zelazny, Moorcock, and the Dream of Vishnu

The cosmos as a god's dream has its Indian archetype in the sleep of Vishnu upon the serpent Ananta, and in the Puranic tale, retold by Heinrich Zimmer in *Myths and Symbols in Indian Art and Civilization* (1946), of the sage Markandeya, who falls from the god's mouth and wanders, terrified, within the dream that is the world. Dunsany's MĀNA-YOOD-SUSHĀĪ (1905) is the European miniature: a sleeping god whose waking would end all things, kept asleep by a drummer. H. P. Lovecraft's Dreamlands (*The Dream-Quest of Unknown Kadath*, written 1926–27) supplied the first shared, mappable dream-realm in modern fantasy, and its cats of Ulthar (1920) are kin to Gaiman's thousand cats. The divergence is moral. Lovecraft's Dreamlands are an aesthetic refuge from an indifferent cosmos; Gaiman's Dreaming is a polity with obligations.

Roger Zelazny's "He Who Shapes" (1965) imagined a therapist who enters and shapes his patients' dreams and is finally drowned in one; "Lord Shaper" is among Dream's titles, as *scop*, "shaper," was the Old English word for poet. Zelazny's Amber novels (from 1970) supplied the dysfunctional royal family of quasi-divine siblings and a cosmology in which a primal Pattern generates all realities, a suggestive neighbour to Destruction's description of the Endless as patterns. Michael Moorcock's cosmic war of Law and Chaos is cited directly in *Season of Mists*, whose claimants to Hell include envoys of Order and Chaos.

7.4 The British Invasion and After

Alan Moore's "The Anatomy Lesson" (*Swamp Thing* #21, 1984) revealed that the Swamp Thing was not a transformed man but a plant that had dreamt it was one, an ontology of identity-as-story from which *The Sandman* descends by filiation (Matthew the raven was Moore's Matt Cable). Moore's *Promethea* (1999–2005) later imagined the Immateria, a realm of imagination inhabited by story-beings sustained by being written, and may be read as a reply to Gaiman's Dreaming. Grant Morrison's *Animal Man* (1988–90) took the opposite route: its protagonist meets his writer, and discarded characters wait in a "Comic Limbo." Morrison exposes the author; Gaiman mythologizes the archive. Mike Carey's *Lucifer* (2000–06), spun from

Season of Mists, follows the abdicated sovereign to the creation of a cosmos of his own, the most radical extension of abdication as freedom. Bill Willingham's *Fables* (2002–15) economized the ladder of persistence: exiled fairy-tale characters grow harder to kill the more widely their stories are known. Popularity there replaces the Endless' functional necessity, and fame does the work that mourning does in *The Sandman*.

7.5 Chesterton, Kafka, Lewis, Tolkien

Chesterton's "The Ethics of Elfland" (*Orthodoxy*, 1908) formulated the Doctrine of Conditional Joy: in fairyland, every happiness hangs upon a single, apparently arbitrary prohibition, and the arbitrariness is the point, since the condition is the shape of the gift. The juridical cosmos of *The Sandman* (Faerie food, Orpheus' backward glance, the centennial appointment, the boon that must be honoured) is Elfland's ethics, extended to its sovereign.

Kafka's "Before the Law" (1915) supplies the Dreaming's gate and the Silver City's bureaucracy; Remiel and Duma, conscripted to administer Hell, are functionaries out of *The Castle*. More decisive is Kafka's brief parable "On Parables," published posthumously. Someone observes that if we only followed the parables we would ourselves become parables, and so be rid of our daily cares; another replies that this, too, is a parable; and the exchange closes by noting that the one has won in reality, while in parable he has lost. Morpheus follows the parable to its end. He becomes one, and loses in reality what he wins in story.

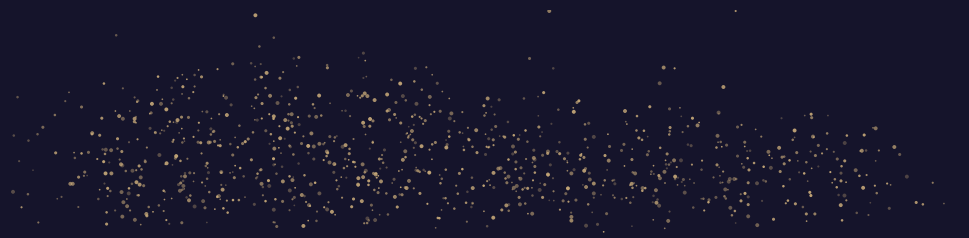
C. S. Lewis's *Till We Have Faces* (1956) is narrated by Orual, who writes her complaint against the gods only to discover that the writing of it was her face; its title asks how the gods can meet us face to face until we have faces. *The Sandman* asks the same question from the other side: how a god can meet us until he has a story. Tolkien's "On Fairy-Stories" (lecture 1939, published 1947) defended Escape as the escape of the prisoner, not the flight of the deserter, which is precisely how *The Sandman* begins; and his "Leaf by Niggle" (1945) imagines a painter whose unfinished tree is completed and made real only after his death. Niggle's tree is Dream's story: real only on the far side of the end.



Conclusion

The King's Two Dreams

The Sandman *resolves the paradox of the anarrative sovereign by separating the dream the king administers from the dream the king is; the doctrine that results, kenotic oneirology, can be stated in twelve theses.*



Theses toward a Kenotic Oneirology

1. **On reality.** Reality is a settlement among fabulations, co-produced by the labour of those who sleep (Heraclitus B75) and secured by the partition of private worlds within a common one (B89). The gravest threats to it are the single dream imposed on all (Dee) and the single dream into which all dissolve (the vortex).
2. **On being.** Being is graded by its mode of support: belief sustains the gods, function the Endless, narration the creatures of dream, embodied finitude the mortal. Each mode has its own manner of perishing, and the passage between modes is the series' fundamental event.
3. **On the Endless.** The Endless are dignities, not deities: corporations sole of conscious life, whose offices persist through the mutation, replacement, resignation, or death of their incumbents.
4. **On Dream.** Within the heptad, Dream is the schematism through which necessity, contingency, cessation, transformation, appetite, and privation become figurable. Being a procedure rather than an object, he has no content of his own.
5. **On narrative.** Narrative selfhood requires mutability, and death is mutability's limit case. To change is to die a little; to die is to change entirely. "Change or die" is, at its limit, an identity.
6. **On the sovereign.** The sovereign of stories is anarrative: the condition of all narratability, himself unnarratable, because narrative borrows its authority from death and the dignity does not die.
7. **On succession.** The anarrative sovereign acquires a story only through kenotic succession, the self-emptying transfer of the dignity to a successor, purchased by the death of the person. Kenosis, in the series' ontology, is a descent of one rung, from office to story.
8. **On abdication.** Abdication does not abolish power; it relocates it. Its ethics are determined by its destination: self-government (Destruction), a worse regime (Lucifer's Hell), or a designated heir (Dream). It may issue from injury as well as from wisdom (Augustus).
9. **On release.** The grammar of release is a grammar of sovereignty. Its humane outcomes do not cancel its asymmetries, and its residue is Oresteian: women's bodies made the instruments of the sovereigns' quarrels, maternal grievance absorbed into paternal succession, and recognition granted to the excluded only in elegy.
10. **On form.** The series' ending is an exit from the oneiric climate of serial fiction; the reader's work in the gutter is the sleepers' labour; and the circularity of *The*

Wake converts an ending into a beginning without converting it back into a middle.

11. **On institution.** The franchise afterlife is the oneiric climate's return as phantasmagoria, underwritten by a legal regime that makes the protagonist a corporation sole in fact. The work's doctrine predicts its fate.
12. **On mortality and immortality.** Mutability is the only form of mortality available to the immortal; succession is the only form of immortality available to the narratable.

Implications

For the philosophy of fiction. Kendall Walton's *Mimesis as Make-Believe* (1990) explains fiction as games of make-believe governed by props; Amie Thomasson's artifactualism explains fictional characters as abstract artifacts dependent on authors, texts, and readers; Meinongian and noneist theories, in Graham Priest's *Towards Non-Being* (2005), explain them as non-existent objects with genuine properties. *The Sandman* proposes a fourth category none of these anticipates: the **officiary**, a being that exists exactly as long as an activity is performed, neither concrete, artifactual, nor non-existent. Dream is not a character in the Dreaming; he is the Dreaming's being-performed.

For the ethics of finitude. The debate between Nagel's deprivation account, Williams's tedium argument, and Fischer's repeatable pleasures has been conducted largely on the axis of duration. The mutability thesis relocates it: what makes a life valuable and narratable is not its brevity or length but its capacity for change, of which death is only the extreme instance. Samuel Scheffler's *Death and the Afterlife* (2013) argued that the value of our present projects depends on the survival of others after us, a "collective afterlife"; *The Wake* dramatizes the claim. Morpheus' life acquires its meaning in the mourning of those who outlive him and in the continuance of the office in another.

For political theology. Between Schmitt's sovereign of decision and Agamben's inoperative throne, the series proposes a third figure: the **sovereign of autothanatic decision**, who decides upon his own inoperativity and thereby secures the continuance of the order he relinquishes. Its theological correlate is kenosis; its juridical correlate is the demise of the Crown.

For comics studies. The work establishes that the formal problem of the serial character (immutability against narrative consumption) can be resolved within the medium, and that the resolution is philosophical before it is commercial. It also

shows that the resolution does not hold: the institution restores what the work has ended.

Coda: Nature's Verdict

The series' last image of its first Dream is a commission for a play about a man who gives up his magic and goes home. Its deepest antecedent is not Shakespeare but Spenser. In the *Two Cantos of Mutabilitie*, the titaness Mutability claims dominion over gods and men, and the court on Arlo Hill appears to concede that all things change. Nature's verdict refuses the concession while granting the fact. All things hate steadfastness and are changed; yet, rightly weighed,

> They are not changed from their first estate;
> But by their change their being doe dilate:
> And turning to themselues at length againe,
> Doe worke their owne perfection so by fate:
> Then ouer them Change doth not rule and raigne;
> But they raigne ouer change, and doe their states maintaine.
> (*The Faerie Queene* VII.vii.58)

This is the doctrine of the King's Two Dreams in early modern English. Morpheus changes, and the change is his death; Dream is not changed from its first estate, but by that change its being dilates. The office reigns over change because its person consented to undergo it. Kafka's parable has the last word on the cost: in reality the King of Dreams has lost. The work's wager is that in parable, which is to say in the only domain he ever ruled, he has won.

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Keywords

Neil Gaiman; *The Sandman*; kenotic oneirology; anarrative sovereign; oneiric commons; graded fabulative ontology; ladder of persistence; anthropomorphic personification; the Endless; corporation sole; *dignitas non moritur*; the King's Two Bodies; Kantorowicz; political theology; abdication; kenosis; succession; Schmitt; Agamben; Benjamin; *Trauerspiel*; "The Storyteller"; narratable self; Arendt; Cavarero; Ricoeur; *idem* and *ipse*; narrative identity; Todorov; *energeia* and *kinesis*; Solon's dictum; mutability thesis; Makropulos problem; Bernard Williams; Hob Gadling; Heraclitus; *ēthos anthrōpōi daimōn*; Spenser's *Mutabilitie Cantos*; Hesiod's *Theogony*; Ovid's Morpheus; Hoffmann's "Der Sandmann"; Andersen's "Ole Lukøje"; Kantian schematism; Schopenhauer; Nietzsche's Apollonian and Dionysian; Orphic theogony; *sparagmos*; Frazer's divine king; Fisher King; Jung's *Answer to Job*; Girard's scapegoat; *Oresteia*; Oresteian remainder; Eumenides; Zeitlin; Calderón's *La vida es sueño*; Ibsen's life-lie; Wilde's "The Decay of Lying"; retroactive ontogenesis; Borges; Calvino; Le Guin; Pullman; Pratchett; Dunsany; Lovecraft's Dreamlands; Zelazny; Faustian bargain; Mann's *Doktor Faustus*; Eco's oneiric climate; seriality; comics studies; McCloud's closure; Groensteen's braiding; *Erwachen*; *Finnegans Wake*; phantasmagoria; franchise afterlife; death of the author; author function; two bodies of the author; Thomasson's artifactualism; philosophy of fiction; ethics of finitude; Orientalism; *A Game of You*; Vertigo Comics.